

MATTHEW O'LEARY

Print Production Lead | Magazines, Catalogs & Publishing

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Professional Summary

Print production leader with 20+ years running production for magazines, 800+ page national retail catalogs, books, and CPG packaging. I own production end to end, from schedules, file standards, and preflight through proofing cycles, color, and printer relationships. I stay hands-on in InDesign, building and fixing the files myself.

Most recently I was Designer & Production Manager for *California* magazine (Cal Alumni Association), taking the Fall 2026 issue from layout and ad preflight through press with Quad. I build the templates, standards, and InDesign automation that let many contributors deliver consistent, press-ready files across multiple titles, without taking creative freedom away from designers.

Core Skills

- **Production leadership:** end-to-end production ownership, schedules and page flow, proofing cycles and release readiness, cross-functional coordination with design, editorial, and photo, and post-press archiving; Jira, Trello, Airtable
- **Prepress, color & image reproduction:** PDF/X preflight, Acrobat Pro, CMYK and spot/Pantone color management, image correction, color separations, pagination, imposition, press checks, and proofing across offset, digital, and large-format
- **Workflow standards & automation:** InDesign templates, parent pages, style architecture and naming, GREP styles, Find/Change queries, Data Merge, JavaScript/ExtendScript scripting, and preflight, export, and delivery standards
- **Publishing:** magazines, alumni and custom publications, national retail catalogs, book interiors and covers, curriculum, and accessible PDF output
- **Printer & vendor management:** file delivery through proof approval and press, press checks, and on-time multi-SKU and seasonal releases
- **Tools:** Adobe InDesign (advanced), Illustrator, Photoshop, Acrobat Pro, Firefly and Generative Fill; ChatGPT, Claude, Midjourney; Figma; Microsoft Office

Professional Experience

Designer & Production Manager | California Magazine (Cal Alumni Association) Aug 2026 – Present
Remote, Contract

- Own the magazine's production from layout through press: page flow, ad preflight, image placement, and press-ready files for editorial pages, advertising, and custom inserts.
- Manage the printer relationship with Quad from file delivery through proof approval and press, against a hard publication schedule.

- Route layouts and proofs through Creative Director and Managing Editor approval cycles, and manage revisions under deadline.
- Built the issue's class notes, obituaries, and masthead sections from scratch. This dense, repetitive content depends on consistent style application at scale.
- Deliver post-press file packaging and web and promotional assets using template-based and AI-assisted workflows.

Production Consultant & Designer | Matt O'Leary Design 2010 – Present Santa Cruz, CA

- Run production for packaging, publishing, and branded-collateral clients from brief through final delivery, including FDA-compliant packaging mechanicals and product labels.
- Create color separations for a screen-printing business from many kinds of starting artwork, for clients including O'Neill Surf Shop.
- Build paneled and tiled large-format files for extra-large trade-show booths, building drapes, and bus wraps.
- Coordinate print and fabrication vendors on materials, proofs, quality control, and delivery, tracking timelines and approvals in Trello.

Production Support Specialist | OBXtek (Defense Language Institute contract) Dec 2024 – Oct 2025
Monterey, CA

- Produced and maintained complex, long-form foreign-language curriculum in InDesign within established templates, styles, and formatting standards.
- Standardized templates and visual assets across 14+ language pipelines, and coordinated deliverables, versions, and deadlines in Airtable.
- Performed quality control and prepared accessible PDFs from finished files, applying accessibility standards to government curriculum.

Senior Designer | Wiser Solutions, Axway, Kiteworks 2014 – 2023 Remote and Palo Alto, CA

- Axway (2018–2022): Built template-driven systems for global print and digital marketing campaigns, improving consistency and delivery speed across distributed teams.
- Wiser Solutions (2022–2023) and Kiteworks (2014–2018): Maintained design-system standards and standardized asset handoffs between remote design and engineering teams.

Creative Lead | FastPencil Oct 2011 – May 2014 Campbell, CA

- Led typographic systems and production for 50+ book interiors and covers a year in InDesign and Illustrator.
- Built complete book templates that set the typography, page structure, and style hierarchy for full-length books.
- Prepared final files for commercial printers, KDP, and IngramSpark with a high rate of first-pass acceptance.

Print Production Manager | McDill Associates Sep 2008 – Nov 2011 Soquel, CA

- Managed print production workflows and designed packaging for national retail brands including Costco, Martinelli's, and Rainbow Light.
- Built and verified dielines, spot-color separations, and regulated copy, and coordinated printers and paper suppliers for on-time multi-SKU rollouts.
- Produced wayfinding, large-format event signage, and brand-activation materials for trade shows including PMA.

Prepress Manager | West Marine Jan 2002 – Aug 2008 Watsonville, CA

- Managed prepress for 800+ page national retail catalogs: preflight, color management, pagination, imposition, proofing, and high-volume seasonal delivery.
- Ran press checks at Midwest printers, and coordinated vendors on schedule, quality, and specifications.

Co-founder | The Juice Surf Magazine 1994 – 2000 Santa Cruz, CA

- Co-founded and ran an independent quarterly surf magazine for about six years, producing roughly 20 issues from editorial through press.

Education

University of California, Santa Cruz | Coursework in Art, Design & Visual Studies